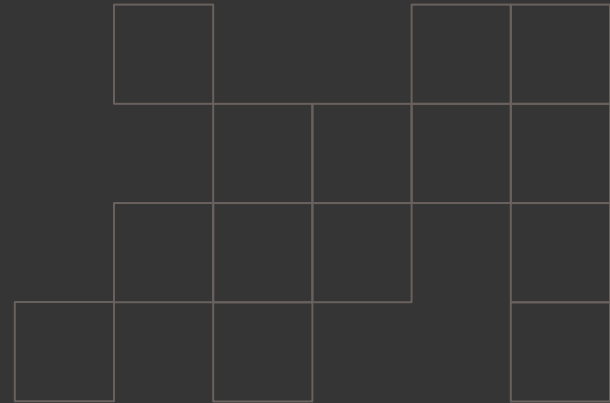


Jess South
2026

Addressing Rising Childcare Costs in the US

February 1, 2026



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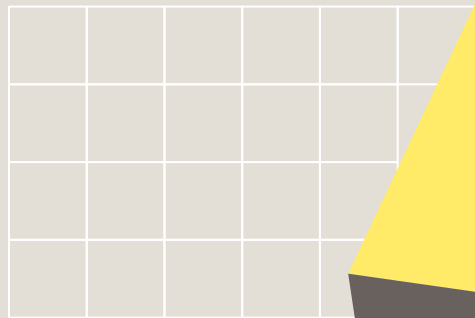
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Childcare's impact on voters

Childcare is a barrier to public participation, namely...

- Parents' ability to participate in civic life
- Economic participation, such as the ability to purchase higher-end or luxury goods
- Public education quality and its effect on developing a well-educated population
- Overall poverty and employment rates

Key Voters & Stakeholders



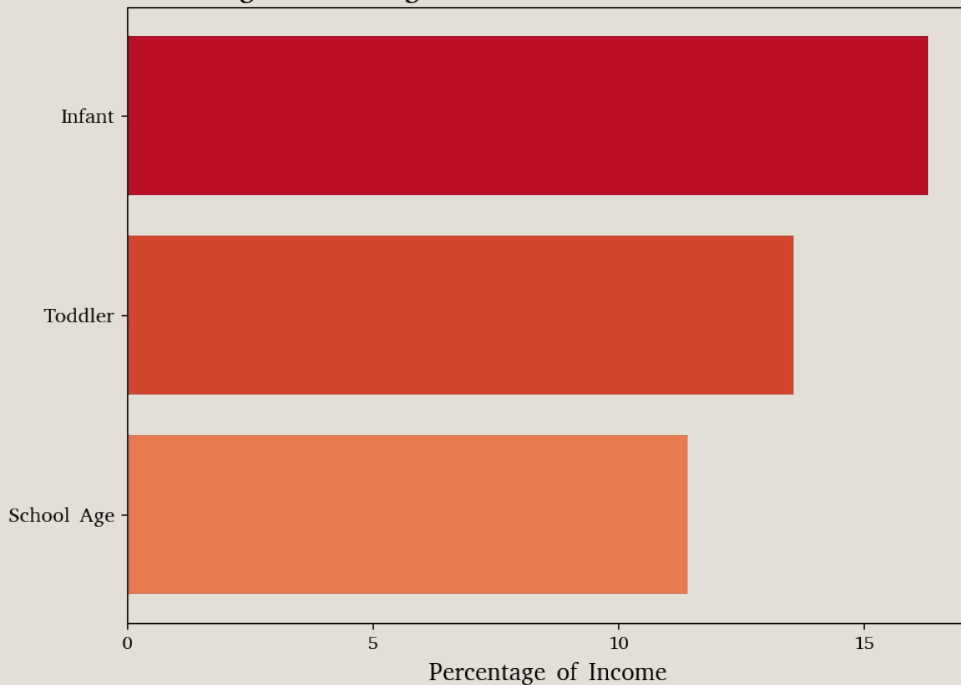
Young Families

This issue disproportionately impacts families with no accrued wealth and therefore impacts the youth vote (18-24).

Working Women

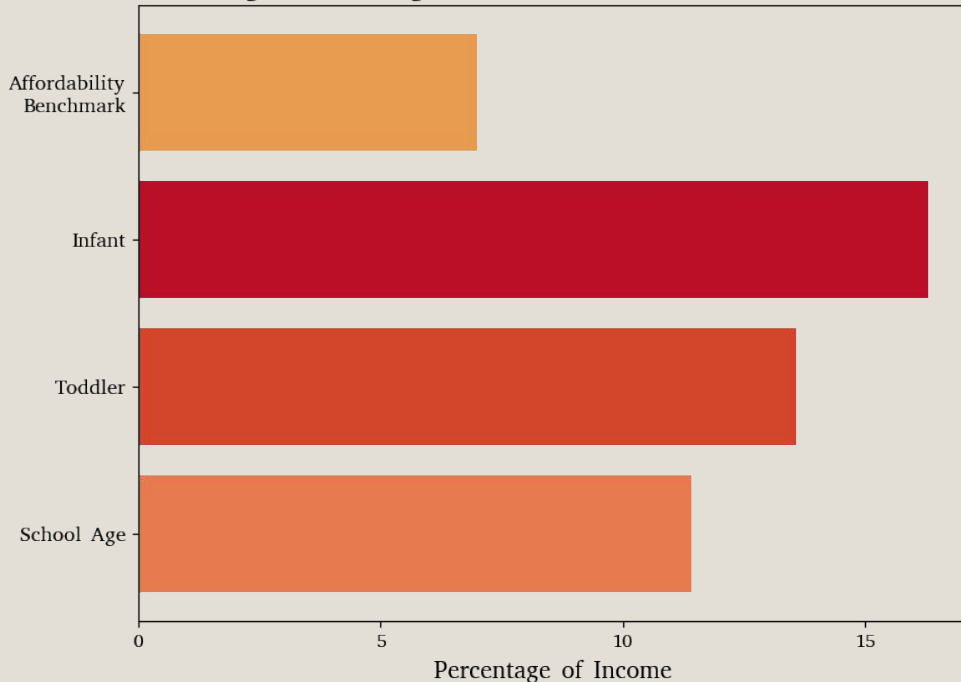
Employed (and educated) women are likely to find childcare to be a voting issue as it impacts their financial freedom and career independence.

Average Percentage of Income That Goes to Childcare



Infant childcare costs
keep new families from
financial freedom.

Average Percentage of Income That Goes to Childcare



Childcare should
cost no more than
7% of income.

The federal Child Care and Development Fund (CCDF) Program sets its affordable benchmark for childcare at **only 7%**[†] of income. **All childcare means exceed this benchmark.**

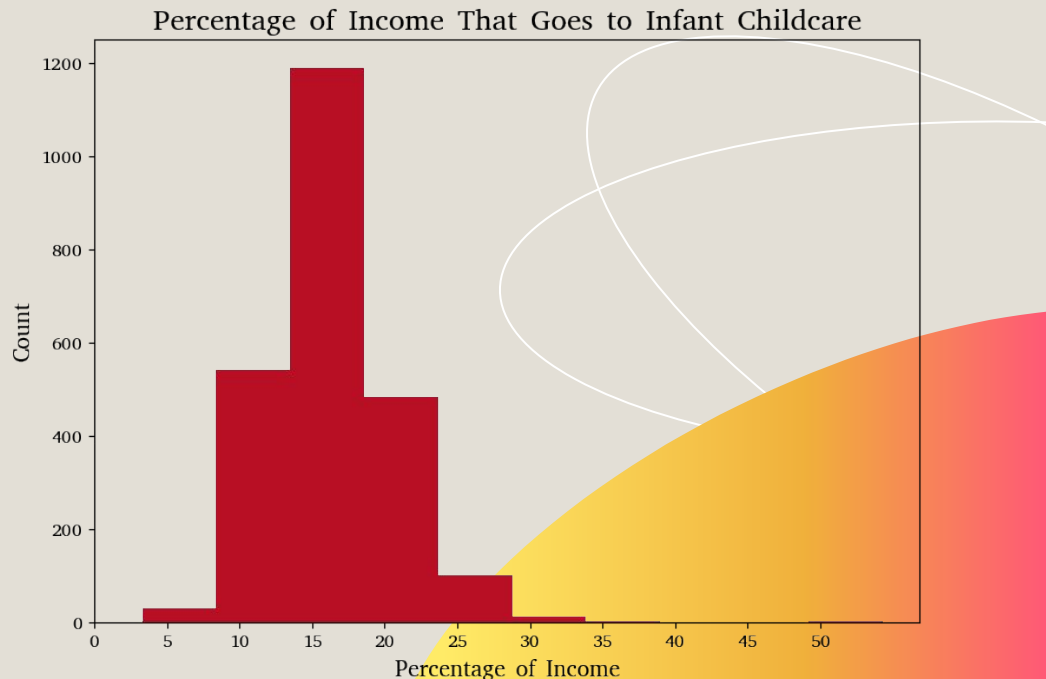
[†] Federal Register

Infant childcare costs as much as groceries.[†]

The Economic Policy Institute recommends paying a *maximum* of 30% of income on rent or mortgage, meaning that **childcare costs are comparable to mortgage payments.**

- The majority of households pay between 15-20% of their income on childcare.
- **Some households pay as much as 50% of their monthly income on childcare costs.**

[†] Economic Policy Institute



Implementing Next Steps

What can we do to repair childcare affordability?

Public Childcare Services

Fund local childcare services such as public daycares, school daycare options, and public preschools.

Subsidize Private Childcare

Identify private childcare institutions by reputable training and/or accreditation and subsidize payments.

Free Childcare For Impoverished Families

For families receiving SNAP or similar assistance, fully waive the cost of childcare and provide services to place children in local programs.



thank you